

Wine apart, even from the base game. There are beasts to hunt, mysteries to solve, gear to acquire and more RPG stuff to do. Toussaint is the quintessential Witcher realm—beautiful on the outside, with a dark underbelly.

The lazy detective

Geralt is tasked by the duchess of Toussaint to eliminate the mysterious beast terrorizing her lands. Investigating a series of murders is his first goal, deciphering a pattern and playing Sherlock Holmes to predict the next victim. During the course of twenty-or-so hours, expect to spend a fair amount of time doing a Witcher's work for meagre pay, but keep in mind that this is a sandbox game as

much as anything. There will still be plenty of time to laze in your own vineyard, ride around aimlessly on horseback, or more importantly, get some Gwent practice in before the standalone game comes out. There's an all-new Skellige deck with over 40 cards, and a tournament to test your card playing skills.

The fashion-conscious soldier

While it has been argued that combat is a weak point in The Witcher 3, I've always felt that it was easy enough to not feel too casual and complex enough to reward strategy. If you dislike The Witcher 3's combat, Blood and Wine is not going to change your mind, however. Expect to encounter a variety of ene-

mies which will require a fair bit of tactical play (pro tip: invest in Igni and Yrden this time and don't rely on Quen as much), ranging from hard-hitting brutes, crafty arachnids to fast-paced invisible apparitions.

Blood and Wine also introduces a new skill system which revolves around Mutations. Once you've completed a secondary quest, a new upgrade system will be available to Geralt. Unlock new skill slots and 12 mutations in total by using ability points or mutagens. Gain passive abilities, empowering melee attacks, sign intensity, offering speed boosts or dismembering foes with fatal blows. While only one Mutation can be active at a time, combining it with mutagens can give Geralt some crazy damage buffs.

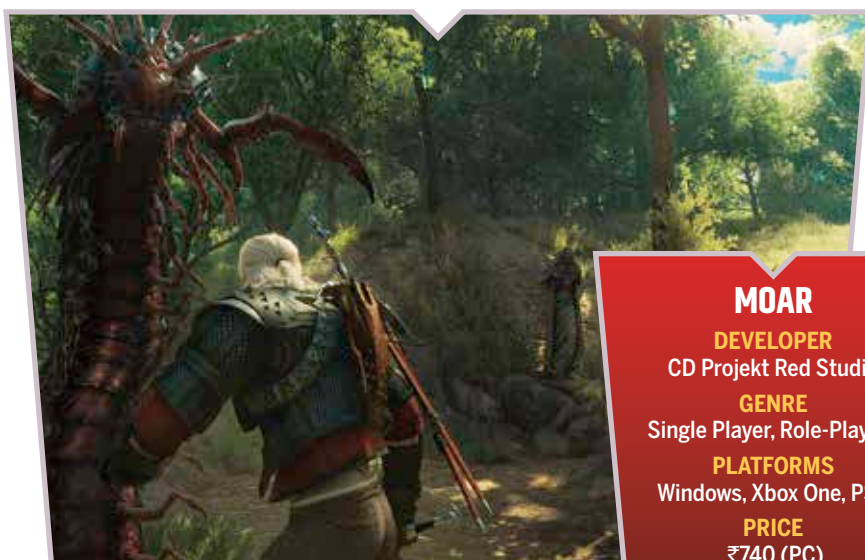
An additional armour tier ("Grandmaster") is also introduced. These are not cheap to craft and diagrams are not easy to come by, but they have the best stats of all armour pieces. There's no other way to describe the visual appearance of these new armour sets other than "badass". So if you want to look like one, there's a bit of wandering to do, but it's worth it in the end. Blood and Wine also features armour dyes—some of which can be purchased at shops, while others can be crafted from diagrams. This was clearly a much requested feature by the community (plus the fact that a lot of us were running around with dumb-looking mismatched armour sets because of their stats), and it's good to see that it's in the game.

The Verdict

The Witcher 3 is one of the greatest RPGs ever made, and Blood and Wine is a fitting farewell to everyone's favourite pale monster slayer.

The story is superbly written and Toussaint is a wonderful setting for such a dark story.

Thanks to a combination of new features, improvements and refinements, the game hasn't been in a better state. Overall, Blood and Wine offers tremendous value for its price as it takes you on a gritty yet unforgettable magical journey. *



MOAR

DEVELOPER

CD Projekt Red Studio

GENRE

Single Player, Role-Playing

PLATFORMS

Windows, Xbox One, PS4

PRICE

₹740 (PC)